



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ann Arbor Orthodox Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.a2oca.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Ann Arbor Orthodox Classical Academy (A2OCA) presents a robust alignment with classical education ideals, anchored in an Orthodox Christian framework. Public-facing materials consistently emphasize formation of wisdom and virtue, a Christian telos, and engagement with classical curriculum and pedagogy (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, memorization, and Socratic dialogue in appropriate grade bands). The school foregrounds a liturgical, communal, and parent-partnered approach, with explicit statements about being Christ-centered and about parents as first educators. Overall, the school demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment across most categories, with particularly strong emphasis in religious foundations, purpose/goal, and curriculum, and clear indicators in pedagogy and community. The Faculty category shows substantial presence (staff, teachers, leadership), but lacks consistently explicit language about the "living curriculum" or teacher as exemplar in the public materials, suggesting a SLIGHTLY less explicit fit in that category. Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials describe an Orthodox Christian environment, Christ-centered curriculum, and liturgical life. For example, the mission frames education as classical in an Orthodox context, with explicit emphasis on "Christ-loving leaders" and honoring God in the curriculum. - Core theological framing appears in statements that a classical education cooperates with church and family and seeks to know God in all things, including Divine Liturgy and Orthodox practice. - Communal liturgical life is referenced (Divine Liturgy, Orthodox Church connections, catechesis, etc.).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; divine; augments the transcendentals and sacred framework (e.g., "true, good, and beautiful"; "Orthodox Christian environment"; "Divine Liturgy"). - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no relativism, secularism, or value-neutral language detected in these sources).

Why this rating - The materials explicitly articulate a transcendent, theological foundation and liturgical/-community life as central to education, aligning with the Relational/Metaphysical core of classical education as described in the classical criteria. Strong mention of truth/goodness/beauty in a theocentric framework corroborates a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Mission statements center on wisdom and virtue in Christ and the formation of the whole person (body, mind, heart, soul) in a classical Christian frame. - Language ties formation to virtue, human flourishing,

and the cultivation of truth, goodness, and beauty, not merely workforce outcomes. - The public messaging emphasizes formation over mere information and the cultivation of character as a core telos (e.g., “Wisdom and Virtue in Christ,” “formation ... in an Orthodox Christian environment”).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; human flourishing; unity of truth/goodness/beauty; liberal education; classical mission; telos; contemplative aims (scholé). - Negative keywords present: minimal to none; the public materials do not foreground workforce-readiness or 21st-century-skills rhetoric in opposition to formation.

Why this rating - The school's stated purpose and goals foreground formation, virtue, and the cultivation of wisdom within a classical framework, matching the classical category's expectations for this dimension.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is framed around liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; trivium) and the quadrivium, with explicit emphasis on Great Books and the Great Conversation. - Historical study across curriculum and engagement with primary/ canonical texts are highlighted (Great Books, Western civilization, biblical literacy; sacred tradition). - Latin/Greek and classical languages are listed, along with a holistic approach to history and the arts in a historically grounded curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium), Great Books/Great Conversation, classical languages (Latin/Greek), history/Western civilization, interdisciplinary harmony, wonder. - Negative keywords present: project-based learning or STEM-first framing as a replacement for history or classical formation are not present in the school materials; no overt substitution of history with social studies language is observed in the sources.

Why this rating - The curriculum descriptions align strongly with classical elements (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, history as a core discipline, cultivation of wonder). This supports CLASSICAL for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical approach combines contemplative elements with rigorous engagement: lower grades emphasize memorization and memory work; upper grades engage in Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetoric (where applicable). This is reflected in the classical pedagogy language and curriculum approach. - The public materials describe a trajectory from memory/chanting (lower grades) to Socratic dialogue and rhetorical training (upper grades). The overall framing supports a pedagogy that blends scholé/restful forms with dialectic/seminar forms at the appropriate levels. - Community integration and liturgical calendar considerations (catechesis, liturgy, and church life) accompany the pedagogy, aligning with a holistic pedagogy typical of classical education within a religious context.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion; seminar; rhetoric; memory work; chanting; restfulness/scholé; liturgical integration; great conversation. - Negative keywords present: The site does not emphasize purely project-based or experiential learning as the dominant mode; there is no prominent rhetoric privileging constructivist paradigms over classical methods in the sources provided.

Why this rating - The pedagogy exhibits a classic progression from memory/recitation toward dialectic and rhetoric, with appropriate restful/Scholé elements. This aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy expectations.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site includes explicit staff and leadership information (e.g., On-line Instructor for Kindergarten to Third Grade; Board of Directors; staff pages). This shows professional teaching adults and formal governance, which supports the notion of a structured, teacher-led environment. - Public materials show teachers as part of the institution and connected to the school's mission (e.g., “Anne Ramirez On-line Instructor,” staff sections, and governance). However, explicit language describing the faculty as “living curriculum” or as exemplary moral mentors (as a core feature) is not clearly stated in the publicly accessible materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: teacher; instructor; staff; board of directors; leadership; professional staff. These reflect a professional faculty, but not a fully explicit classical-education faculty portrait (e.g., “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” or “faculty as mentors” language is not overtly present in these public materials). - Negative keywords present: not explicitly present; there is no direct counterframe that would signal a departure from classical aims in the faculty materials.

Why this rating - The presence of formal faculty structures (staff, instructors, board) supports a CLASSICAL alignment, but the lack of explicit language about the faculty as the living curriculum or deeply cultivated mentor-teacher archetypes in the public-facing content leads to a SYMPATHETIC SLANT toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than full CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school prominently positions parents as essential collaborators and “the first educators” of their children, with explicit statements about parent partnership and Christian education within a classical frame. - Materials emphasize parental involvement and formation (parent partnerships, discussions around curriculum, and opportunities for families to engage with classical education content). - The communications frame a family and parish-connected community (Orthodox Church life, liturgy, catechesis) as integral to the school’s ecosystem, with explicit calls to participate in parish life and school events.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental formation; open campus; family involvement; home-school connection; community of learners; parent covenant. - Negative keywords present: none observed in the sources; no consumer-language or minimal involvement rhetoric found in the school materials.

Why this rating - The school’s materials strongly emphasize parent partnership, family formation, and open community engagement, which aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Ranking

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Overall, the school’s public-facing content demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment, with the strongest signals in religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose/goal, curriculum, pedagogy, and parents/community. The Faculty category shows substantial classical alignment through formal staff structures but lacks explicit, consistent language about teachers as living exemplars or the living curriculum, which suggests a leaning toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in that specific area. Given the preponderance of evidence across categories, the aggregate classification for Ann Arbor Orthodox Classical Academy is CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle

- Strengthen explicit articulation of the faculty as the living curriculum: add statements on teacher exemplarity, mentorship, and the role of teachers as living embodiments of classical formation (e.g., portraits of a teacher, teacher training in classical pedagogy, and teacher-student mentor relationships).
- Expand public-facing language to consistently tie faculty roles to classical formation (e.g., “the faculty are the living curriculum” and “great books seminars for faculty”).
- Maintain and amplify explicit language around “Scholé” and contemplative/restful learning as a core pedagogical principle across more grade levels, with concrete examples and policy statements.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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